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The Coupling of Color Systems Within *Amelie*

In the close-up photobook shot in *Amelie*, the photobook entirely takes over and fills the screen with its arrangement of torn and incomplete but somehow tenderly whole photos. As Amelie flips through the many pages, the individuals change, but the striking colors remain and capture the scene. There is indeed a practical explanation for these colors, which are uncharacteristic of the reality of passport photos, but there is also an inherent belonging of these hues within the world of Amelie Poulain. In this scene, color serves the purpose of bridging Amelie and the rest of the world.

The coloring of the background is neutral, subdued, and rather plain, serving as a sharp contrast for the photos themselves. Passport photos are typically shot under normal lighting, except these ones, which are tainted with odd color filters and odd levels of exposures. The images, vivid and fun, add a cheery and wondrous tone to the photobook as a whole. The adventures of color in this shot is the adventure that Amelie takes life as. The layout of colors all across each page, instead of only in the center of the frame, draws the audience's eyes to the book as a work of art. Distinct spaces are occupied by distinct faces and distinct colors. This establishes a meditative rhythm consistent with the rest of the film's expansion on voyeurism. Amelie experiences the pleasure of scanning the preciousness and beauty of the people, enjoying the way that she can see them in this particular light.

The color also focuses away from Amelie and instead on these new people. Unlike other scenes, where often Amelie stands out by wearing a vivid hue of red, in this scene the only part

of Amelie that is shown is her skin, which is neutral-colored. The other people in the frame are the ones in distinct colors. Unsurprisingly, at the same time in the narrative, Amelie shifts her focus outwards on other people and decides to interject herself in their lives as a helper angel. The distinct coloring of these photos casts the photos as the subjects of this shot, a parallel to how Amelie frames the other people around her as the main objects of her energy and attention.

The oddness of the color scheme matches the rest of the film's position between reality and fantasy. Passports photos are ordinarily normal, but distortions and discolorations can make them appear unlike their real life subjects. The photos communicate that Amelie's imaginary world might not be entirely segregated from reality. The photobook is a termination to her isolation because she has found a real object that resembles her own reality. In this photobook, the colors belong to the real world yet show that Amelie's world, shot in bright colors and recurring color patterns, is not dissimilar.

The diffusion of colors symbolizes the diffusion of Amelie's loneliness, as the intermediary between Amelie and the photobook is Nino. Nino also likes to see people in this colored reality and keeps these shots that seem so far from reality. Amelie's vividly and quirkily colored world, which has seemingly been her own unique experience, is also experienced by Nino as he puts the book together. Later on in the film, the photobook obviously serves as a prop that brings Amelie and Nino together, yet at this moment color is already bringing them together; they are both surrounded by and attracted to colors.

Color is an expressive device, and in this scene specifically, it weaves together self-expression as a connecting experience among individuals. The photos are static captured expressions of people. Though the subjects of the photos didn't like how they were portrayed by the photos and ripped them apart in assumed unhappiness, they are found beautiful by Nino, who

takes the time to reconstruct them. The photobook is in turn a form of creative expression for Nino, a way to make a colored reality of his own. Amelie then finds the creative expression of Nino beautiful because she shares a similar admiration for the world as he does for these stranger's snapshots. Color is an outlet for both of them—a creative outlet for Nino and for Amelie a reprieve from loneliness. Though untrue to reality, the colors within the shot are true between Amelie and Nino.